

SALUTATIONS
Tourists at the Namo Namah Ghat

Photographs by ANAND SINGH

Banaras Hindu University (BHU) campus here.

Currently, projects worth Rs 11,842 crore are under way (see *A Few Big Plans*), including a Rs 645 crore cable car ropeway. The 3.75 km ropeway will connect the Cantonment railway station to Godowlia Chowk with stops at the Kashi Corridor, the Kashi Vishwanath temple and Dashashwamedh Ghat. When it opens in 2025, it is expected to carry at least 30,000 passengers a day. Ramesh Gupta, who runs a puja *samagri* (material) store in Godowlia, says, "The ropeway should ease matters considerably. Right now, it takes one and a half hours to go from Godowlia to the Cantt station during the day, which is why traders prefer to pick up stock after midnight."

Baba Radheshyam, who stays next to the Hanuman temple behind Assi Ghat, says everything has changed since Modi chose Varanasi as his constituency. "The restoration of the ghats and temples aside, the place is no longer dingy and filthy...there are lights everywhere," he says. Indeed, the PM's mission of Swachh Varanasi began soon after he first took charge. His visit to the temple town on November 8, 2014, became memorable for the photo-op of Modi sweeping Assi Ghat. Nearly nine years later, Varanasi's 84 ghats have all been refurbished—they are now lit up at night (a project that cost Rs 20 crore), the



"VARANASI'S ECONOMY IS LARGELY DEPENDENT ON THE KASHI VISHWANATH TEMPLE AND THE GHATS, WHICH IS WHY THE GOVERNMENT PROJECTS HAVE FOCUSED ON INCREASING THE CITY'S GRANDEUR"

–KAUSHAL RAJ SHARMA
Commissioner, Varanasi division